

5.1.2 Simple Context-Menu Encryption

There are many, many freeware utilities out there that offer simple, one-click encryption. You right-click a file, select “Encrypt”, supply a password, and that’s it—the file won’t open again until the correct password is supplied! One example we came across is Crypt4Free, at www.secureaction.com/encryption_free/. This isn’t a software we’re particularly recommending, but it’s a good example of all the software out there that can do this for you and make life a little simpler. Wrote a mail you don’t want anyone to see? Encrypt it! Took down some notes at office in a text file that no-one else should be looking at? One right-click and a password later, and you’re done! It really is that simple.

Alas, such software are a dime a dozen, and where they lack is in the following areas:

- If you forget your password, you have no way of recovering your file. No password hints!
- The same holds even if you mistype your password. You’ll have no way of knowing that you mistyped it, and the file will get encrypted—gone for good.
- Such software typically cannot deal with large files, and give errors when you try to do it—or they hang your computer.
- There’s no way of managing all the files you encrypted, from one central location.
- These usually don’t come with support for folder encryption.

5.1.3 Comprehensive Encryption Software

If you’re willing to go paid, you’ll get software that encrypts entire drives for you, creating virtual folders where you can store anything you want to in encrypted form. An example is to be found at www.reflex-magnetics.co.uk/products/datavault/